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Vulkan, the Future of Open Graphics APIs

>>Why have some of the biggest players in the industry decided to create entirely new graphics APIs all of a sudden? Is this an unlikely coincidence or does it signify some kind of a larger shift in the industry?> by Kshitij Sobti

Apple's Metal, AMD's Mantle, Microsoft's DirectX 12, Khronos' glNext and now Vulkan, the world of graphics computing seems to have exploded with new APIs, standards and frameworks of late. One has to wonder what exactly is going on.

If we look at what all of these have in common, it becomes clear that it is the latter, a growing consensus in the industry about what the future of graphics development should look like.

This common base that all the above technologies share, is a focus on making a graphics API that gives developers more direct access to the hardware, with fewer layers of abstraction and code between the hardware a developer writes, and software a developer writes.

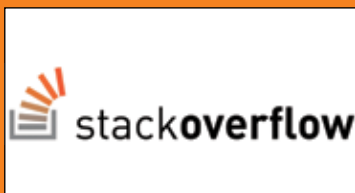
To understand why this is important for the future of graphics processing, let us first look at a brief history of GPU technology, and graphics APIs.

A Brief History of the GPU

What we would today call a GPU – the term was coined after the technology had already existed for many years – has been around for over two decades now, and it has not been immune to Moore's law.

In many ways the advancement of GPUs has been even more substantial than that of the CPU. The architecture of GPU and the approach to graphical software development have changed substantially. One of the biggest such changes has been the move from a fixed-function pipeline to the shader-based pipeline that exists today.

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